The Simplicity of Joy — Shabbos Chol HaMoed Sukkos

On the first day of Sukkos, as I was walking home from my lunch at a friends house to go back to my own sukkah, I heard one of my neighbor's voices from his sukkah so I wished him a chag sameach and had a small chat with him. We couldn't see each other, only hear one another's voices through the thin walls. We spoke for a few moments, laughing.
And I thought about what a powerful picture this is. The sukkah is vulnerability. Everyone can hear (as we have spoken in the recent times of the power of hearing) and sometimes people can even see in. It's a space of honesty and exposure, of being real with one another and with Hashem.

Before I left this conversation to continue home, my neighbor asked a question that lingered with me all week:

> "What's so unique about Sukkos that it alone is called Zman Simchaseinu — the Season of Our Joy?"

We know that every Yom Tov has joy — v'samachta b'chagecha applies to all.
Yet only Sukkos and Shmini Atzeres carry that title in our davening. Pesach is zman cheiruseinu, the time of our freedom. Shavuos is zman matan Toraseinu, the time of the giving of the Torah. But Sukkos? Zman simchaseinu.
Why?

Why Only Sukkos Is Called "Zman Simchaseinu"

When we look at the other festivals, they each carry lofty, heavy work.
Pesach demands physical labor and expense — kashering kitchens, cleaning, preparing, staying up late, and praying that the credit card bill won't crush us. It's a celebration of freedom, but the work never really stops.

Shavuos celebrates the giving of the Torah — the highest, most spiritual moment in history. But many of us, after a sleepless night of learning, aren't feeling lofty; we're exhausted.

Rosh Hashanah is the day of awe, the sound of the shofar shaking us to our core. Yom Kippur is the day of forgiveness, fasting, and soul-searching.

Each of these days has its beauty — but Sukkos is different.
Sukkos is simple. Sukkos is joy that anyone can reach.
We go outside of our homes and into our Sukkahs. We sit with family. We eat, sing, and breathe under the stars (and under the schach). There's no marble, no gold, no grandeur — just a few boards and branches, and a heart full of gratitude.

The Joy of Water and Simplicity

Even more than the above, the Gemara says:

> “Mi shelo ra’ah simchas beis ha-shoeivah, lo ra’ah simcha miyamav.”
> — Sukkah 51a
> Whoever never saw the joy of the Water-Drawing Celebration has never truly seen joy in his life.

At first glance, this makes no sense. What’s so exciting about pouring water on the Mizbeach? Wine makes sense — it’s rich, flavorful, and festive. Oil offerings had fragrance and texture, and flour offerings nourished. Each of these has substance and symbolism, something tangible to engage the senses. But water? It’s plain, colorless, and everywhere — the simplest of all elements, with no taste or scent of its own, and yet it becomes the most elevated offering of all.

Yet precisely because it’s simple, it’s perfect.

In those times, this simplicity was no small thing. Drawing the water from the Shiloach spring was done with song, dancing, and overflowing joy. People would gather all night in the Beis HaMikdash to watch the kohanim ascend with golden flasks, and when the morning arrived the water was poured on the Mizbeach together with wine. It was more than a ritual—it was a prayer for rain, for blessing, for life itself.

Water was both precious and abundant. It could cost nothing when drawn from a spring, yet it was priceless when withheld from the land. Everyone needed it, rich and poor alike, and without it there would be no crops, no sustenance, no survival. By offering water, we were in truth offering our dependency, saying: Hashem, everything we have flows from You.

In contrast to the expensive ingredients of other offerings, the water libation represented accessibility. It wasn’t about wealth or status; anyone could relate to it. That is why the simcha was so great—the people saw themselves in the act. The farmer, the craftsman, the scholar, the child—all could feel the same joy, for all depend equally on water and on Hashem’s kindness. The Mishnah (Rosh Hashanah 1:2) teaches that on Sukkos, the world is judged for water — the source of all life.
We take the most basic element of existence, the one that everyone shares equally, and we pour it out before Hashem with song and dance.
That’s simcha. That’s humility. That’s love.

Today, water still brings that same joy and necessity. We might take it for granted when it pours from a faucet or fills a bottle, but our dependence hasn’t changed. We die without it, our crops wither without rain, our very bodies are mostly water. It cleanses, hydrates, refreshes, and sustains all forms of life. In every home, whether rich or poor, we still bless Hashem for providing it, and when the rains come in their season, we feel relief and gratitude.

That was the meaning of the water drawing: a people praying together for life itself, recognizing that all blessing flows from Heaven. Sukkos becomes the time when we celebrate that simplest, most essential gift—the gift that keeps us alive and connects us to Hashem’s kindness every day.

Water and Torah

Chazal (Taanis 7a) compare Torah to water, and as Rashi notes on the story of Yosef being cast into the pit (Bereishis 37:24) — 'Ha'bor reik ein bo mayim' — there was no water, meaning no Torah. From there we learn the phrase 'ein mayim ela Torah,' that water is Torah itself:

> "Just as water descends from a high place to a low place, so too the words of Torah rest only in one who is humble."

Water flows downward, humbly finding the lowest point — the same way the Torah enters the heart that's open, not proud.
Just as no life can exist without water, no soul can thrive without Torah.
And both are available to everyone. Water isn't reserved for scholars, nobles, or the wealthy, and neither is Torah.

This is also part of the joy of Sukkos: Hashem says, "Now that we've passed through awe and forgiveness, come and live simply with Me. Sit in My shade. Drink water. Learn My Torah. Be."

The Mitzvah Itself Is Joy

The Rambam (Hilchos Lulav 8:15) writes:

> "Ha-simcha she'yismach adam b'asiyas ha-mitzvah u'b'ahavas ha-El — avodah gedolah hi."
> The joy one feels in doing a mitzvah and in loving Hashem who commanded it is itself a great form of Divine service.

We don't dance because life is perfect, we dance because we're doing His will.
The mitzvah itself brings joy.
When I sit in the sukkah, shake the lulav, make kiddush, or teach my child Aleph-Beis, that's joy. Because it on its own is purpose, and purpose is happiness.

Torah and Water in Daily Life

We sometimes overcomplicate things and forget that Torah, like water, can be simple and refreshing at every level of our growth. In learning, we speak of Pardes — Pshat, Remez, Drash, and Sod. The Pshat, the plain meaning, is like pure water: clear, essential, and sustaining. When we are thirsty, we don't need to flavor the water; we just need to drink it. If we wish, we can add taste later — hints of Remez, layers of Drash, the richness of Sod — but we must always begin with the simple water itself.

As we grow, we can draw from deeper wells, but we must never lose the simplicity that gives life. If one cannot drink simple water, no amount of flavoring will quench their thirst. The same is true with Torah: if we do not start with the Pshat, the straightforward message of Hashem's word, we lose the foundation for everything that follows. And so, even when we ascend to

higher understanding, we are still drinking that same life-giving water, just with added sweetness and depth.

Because even in droughts, there's always some water left — a spring underground, a verse in our hearts, a drop of Torah waiting to quench us.

Those Who Cannot Sit in Their Sukkahs

And yet, as we sit in our sukkahs this Shabbos, surrounded by our families and joy, we cannot forget our brothers and sisters who cannot.
Our soldiers, our security forces, our doctors and nurses. About these, we have a strong learning directly from masechta Sukkah, "shluchei mitzvah", those engaged in a mitzvah, whom the Gemara (Sukkah 25a) teaches are patur min ha-mitzvah, exempt from another mitzvah while engaged in one.

And what mitzvah are they involved in? They are protecting life, the greatest mitzvah of all. Just as David HaMelech, after battle, rejoiced before Hashem with song and dance (Shmuel II 6:14), their service, too, is bound to joy which they will be able to carry out in a strong and beutiful way many of us can't understand.
As the Navi Nechemiah said:

> "Ki chedvas Hashem hi ma'uzchem" — the joy of Hashem is your strength.
> (Nechemiah 8:10)

We, in our sukkahs, hold that joy for them. We carry it for those who are carrying us.

Closing Blessing

Sukkos teaches us that holiness isn't only in heaven. It's in a few boards, a bamboo mat, a family meal, a cup of water, a line of Torah.
It's the season when Hashem invites us to celebrate not what we own, but Who we belong to.

May this Shabbos Chol HaMoed Sukkos be filled with that kind of joy — simple, pure, and shared.
May those who protect us soon sit peacefully in their own sukkahs, under the ultimate sukkah of peace — sukkas shlomecha.

Shabbat Shalom, Chag Sameach, u'Mayim Rabim lo yuchlu l'chabos es ha'ahavah — May the many waters never extinguish our love for Hashem.